## Introduction

Maritime sociology is less a subfield of sociology, more an assemblage of diversified theoretical frame for maritime social research focused on the relationship between human societies and the marine environment. It examines how social structures, cultures, and institutions develop in maritime contexts (in relation with the Sea, on ships, in ports, port cities, coastal communities) and how the ocean itself influences social life[1][2]. While interest in maritime social phenomena dates back over a century, early inquiries were sporadic and seldom integrated into mainstream sociological theory[3]. By the late 20th century, however, two scholars – Michael Poole and Ludwik Janiszewski – independently developed influential theoretical frameworks that helped formalize maritime sociology as a distinct area of study. This article provides a literature-based review and comparative analysis of Poole's and Janiszewski's contributions. We first situate their work in the historical emergence of maritime sociology, then examine each thinker's theoretical approach in depth. A comparative section analyzes their ontologies, methodologies, and focal research objects side by side. Finally, we consider their legacy and relevance for contemporary marine social sciences, including mid-range theory development, the concept of **maritimization** (marynizacja), the marine social reality, the maritime factor, and their relevance to maritime social sciences.

## Historical Emergence of Maritime Sociology

Maritime sociology began taking shape as a recognized field in the mid-20th century, although its roots extend earlier. Poole notes that "for upwards of a century there has been a recurrent, if fitful, interest in the systematic study of a broad range of social phenomena within the maritime environment"[3]. Early sociological and anthropological studies examined seafaring life – for example, communities of fishermen and sailors – but these studies were often isolated case analyses. By the 1960s and 1970s, scholars started calling for a more coherent subdiscipline. In Poland, **Aleksander Matejko** in 1964 coined the term *socjologia ludzi morza* (sociology of people of the sea) and argued for studying "social communities living and working at sea or on the coast"[4]. **Aurelia Polańska** (1964) has published a research article giving monographic study of deep-sea Polish fishermen. A few years later, **Janusz Sztumski (1971)** introduced the concept of "nautical sociology," defining it as the study of *"the impact of nautical professional activities on the process of shaping human coexistence, researching the various structures emerging as a result (e.g. vessel crews) and various social creations – both material (e.g. seamen's role models) and nonmaterial (e.g. superstitions) – and analyzing special institutions established in the process of conquering maritime areas"*[5]. This early Polish work already highlighted a key theme: the sea as a distinct environment that shapes human social organization (through work patterns, institutions, and culture). By 1981, **Tadeusz Woźniak** used the term *"nautic (maritime) sociology"* to describe the field as focusing on *"phenomena and processes of emergence, development, and collapse of various social communities whose life and work contribute to the character and intensity of society's and state's functioning"*[6].

Parallel developments occurred internationally. Maritime anthropologists and sociologists in the 1960s–70s studied seafarers, port labor, and fishing communities in various countries (e.g. Britain, Norway, Canada), though these studies were not yet unified by a common theoretical framework. A notable early definition came from **W.R. Rosengren (1973)**, who defined maritime

sociology as *"identifying in specific cases the social and cultural forces which determine the specific definitions of the marine environment which shape its use and exploitation."*[7] This definition underscored that human perceptions and social forces mediate how the ocean is used – an important insight that maritime sociology would continue to explore. However, as Poole observed, much of this burgeoning literature remained ad hoc and peripheral to general sociology: *"the analytical premises have generally been circumscribed and, above all, insufficiently integrated into central themes within sociology itself"*[8]. In other words, by the early 1980s there was a substantial body of maritime-related studies, but their concepts (e.g. *"total institution," "community," "deviant behavior"* in shipboard or port settings) had been developed inductively without strong linkage to classical sociological theory[9].

It was against this backdrop that Michael Poole (in the UK) and Ludwik Janiszewski (in Poland) each put forward comprehensive frameworks for maritime sociology in the late 1970s and early 1980s. Poole's landmark paper *"Maritime sociology: towards a delimitation of themes and analytical frameworks"* (1981) sought to evaluate the field's state of development and chart directions for conceptual and empirical advancement[10]. Janiszewski, a sociologist at the University of Szczecin, articulated his vision of "*socjologia morska"* (maritime sociology) in a series of works around the same time (e.g. Janiszewski, 1971; Janiszewski 1978; Janiszewski & Sosnowski 1984). He built on the Polish theoretical canon to solidify maritime sociology as a *"middle range theory"* with its own distinct subject matter and concepts[11]. Both thinkers were pivotal: Poole provided an Anglophone synthesis aligning maritime studies with general sociological concepts, while Janiszewski provided a systematic Polish-language framework centered on the ocean's societal role. In the following sections, we examine each scholar's theoretical contributions in detail.

## Michael Poole's Theoretical Contributions

**Michael Poole** was among the first in the English-speaking world to explicitly delineate the scope and frameworks of maritime sociology. Writing in 1981, Poole noted that although interest in maritime social phenomena was longstanding, the field had yet to mature theoretically: researchers had rarely formulated *"precise models to test the significance of major propositions in general currency"*[12]. His contribution was twofold: (1) to review and organize the major thematic areas of maritime social research, and (2) to advocate integrating these topics with classical sociological theories and methodologies.

**Delimiting the Field** – Poole addressed the question of what *counts* as maritime sociology. He acknowledged a foundational definition (citing Rosengren 1973) that maritime sociology investigates how social and cultural forces define the marine environment's use[7]. However, he argued that two problems persisted: *"the nature and character of [the] social and cultural forces" at work, and* "the precise social groups and relationships to be incorporated in this area of study"*[13]. In other words, researchers disagreed on which causal factors to emphasize and which populations to include. Poole therefore mapped out the domain expansively. He affirmed that obvious core subjects are the seafarers themselves* – "the officers and crew on board ships" *whether in transportation (merchant seafarers) or extraction (fishermen) – but he noted ambiguity at the margins:* "the inclusion of dockworkers (longshoremen) and shipbuilders, while on balance defensible, is clearly open to considerable dispute."*[14] He also pointed to* other *maritime-related groups in need of sociological attention, such as offshore oil and gas workers,*

*lighthouse operators, and lifeboat crews, as well as the relationships between seagoing personnel and their shore-based counterparts (families, shipping companies, maritime trade unions, etc.)[15]. By highlighting these, Poole effectively broadened the field's remit beyond ship crews to a whole* **maritime social system** linking sea and land. This inclusive view echoed contemporary notions that maritime communities are not isolated; rather, they exist in relation to shore institutions and global industries.

**Thematic Frameworks** – A key feature of Poole's work is his effort to connect maritime sociology topics to general sociological concepts. He outlined several *focal themes for analysis*, explicitly mirroring classical frameworks[16]. These themes included: *(a) the concept of a social system,* (b) *community and association,* (c) *social action and culture,* (d) *structure, differentiation and stratification,* (e) *social processes (e.g. recruitment and socialization),* (f) *social change (especially technological impacts),* and (g) *conflict and deviance*[17]. By structuring the maritime domain into these categories, Poole was effectively saying: we should analyze shipboard life, port communities, and maritime industries with the same theoretical lenses used elsewhere – for instance, examining the ship as a **social system** with roles and hierarchies, or understanding a seafaring crew as a **profession-tied community** with its own culture and norms. Indeed, Poole discussed how early maritime sociologists had compared the ship's company to other organizations, often noting its formal hierarchy and functional interdependence (a perspective rooted in structural-functionalism)[18][19]. He cited Vilhelm Aubert's analysis that a ship's ultimate objective (e.g. production or transport) is supported by patterns of proximity, complementarity, recruitment, socialization, stratification, and so on, among crew members[19]. At the same time, Poole observed that much of this earlier work generated *"grounded theories"* specific to maritime cases without referencing broader theories of social order, such as Talcott Parsons' AGIL scheme for system stability[20]. He argued that concepts like **order and integration** should be explicitly considered – for example, how does a shipboard social system achieve integration and resolve the *"problem of order"* that all social systems face?[21].

Another major theme Poole examined was the classic **community–association** dichotomy (Gemeinschaft vs. Gesellschaft) in maritime settings[22][23]. Early maritime sociological literature often portrayed seafarers (or longshoremen, fishing folk, etc.) as forming tight-knit *communities* with shared identity and solidarity, even as they participated in formal *associations* like unions or companies[24][25]. Poole reviewed studies showing that features of Gemeinschaft persisted among maritime workers – e.g. kinship ties, mutual obligations, and a distinct subculture among dockworkers[26][25] – which could underpin effective collective organization. However, modernization (larger ships, new technologies, global crews) was seen to erode some of the traditional community aspects over time[27]. By bringing in this sociological distinction, Poole connected maritime sociology to well-established theory about how communities transform under industrial pressures. Similarly, under his theme of **social action and culture**, Poole invoked Max Weber's typology of social action, suggesting how *value-rational*, *instrumental*, *affective*, and *traditional* actions might manifest in a maritime context (e.g. sailors driven by adventure ethos vs. economic gain vs. family tradition)[28][29]. He even summarized research on **push–pull factors** influencing seafaring careers – why individuals *leave* or *stay* at sea – linking it to exchange theory and occupational turnover models[30][31].

**Integration with Mainstream Sociology** – Beyond mapping themes, Poole's overarching contribution was his call to elevate maritime sociology from a descriptive, mid-stage field into a more theoretically robust discipline. He noted that many concepts applied to maritime life (such

as Goffman's idea of the ship as a **total institution**, or the notion of deviant subcultures among seafarers) had been introduced inductively[9]. For example, researchers asked whether the strict regimented life aboard naval or merchant ships qualified those vessels as *"total institutions"* akin to prisons or monasteries – a reasonable question, but one often explored without fully engaging Goffman's theory. Poole contended that *"if maritime sociology is ever to become sophisticated and conceptually adequate, such analyses must be supplemented – even ultimately replaced – by more deductive modes of inquiry in which mainstream concepts are explicitly applied and tested."*[32] In practical terms, this meant designing studies to *verify* hypotheses drawn from general sociology (e.g. Does a cargo ship exhibit the four functions of Parsons' social system model? Do port communities maintain *Gemeinschaft* characteristics and how does that affect their formal organizations?). Poole also stressed that maritime sociology should embrace interdisciplinary factors: while clearly focused on social and cultural phenomena, it must account for *"economic changes, governmental policies, legislative enactments and technological movements"* that impact maritime social relations[33]. This reflects an institutionalist bent – recognizing that political-economy and technology are integral to the context in which maritime social structures evolve. In sum, Poole's work provided a blueprint for maritime sociology to mature: he delineated its scope, tethered its subject matter to core sociological concepts, and urged a move from case-specific insights to theory-driven research.

## Ludwik Janiszewski's Theoretical Contributions

**Ludwik Janiszewski** developed his maritime sociology framework within the Polish sociological tradition, offering a richly conceptualized and environment-centered perspective. Janiszewski's influence is deeply tied to what he termed the **"maritime social reality"** (*morska rzeczywistość społeczna*). From an ontological standpoint, he argued that social reality connected with the sea is *qualitatively distinct* from that of land-based society[2]. The ocean's natural characteristics – its geography, climate, and ecology – and the human activities oriented toward the sea combine to create a specific sphere of social life. As Janiszewski wrote, maritime reality differs from "landed" reality in its fundamental natural, economic, and cultural bases, and *"the distinctness of these bases exerts a deep and lasting influence on people's social situation, on the structure of social relations and interdependencies, on systems of human bonds, behavior patterns and value systems, and on their ways of life and work"*[2]. In other words, being a member of a seafaring community or working in a maritime occupation imprints a particular social experience, shaped in part by the ocean's physical and symbolic power.

Central to Janiszewski's theory is the concept of **maritimization** (*marynizacja*), which he presented as a broad, dynamic process explaining the reciprocal relationship between society and the sea. He first introduced maritimization as *"a universal process of the sea's influence on social reality,"* which serves as a theoretical foundation for maritime sociology[34]. This concept posits two fundamental causal factors in shaping maritime social reality: **(1)** the *"sea factor"* – the sea as a natural environment (with its biological, climatic, and geographic conditions), and **(2)** the *"social factor"* – human activities directed toward or involving the sea[35]. Maritimization, in Janiszewski's view, occurs at the intersection of these factors. He conceived it as a dual-character process: both *"spontaneous"* (arising organically from individuals' needs and the natural course of things) and *"directed"* (planned and guided by human interests and values). In other words, societies can be drawn to the sea through innate geographic-economic opportunities or cultural inclinations, but they can also consciously pursue maritime development through policy and

strategy. Janiszewski described maritimization as a **complex suite of phenomena and processes** manifesting across multiple dimensions of social life. In his analysis, maritimization encompassed at least seven key aspects of societal change, which can be summarized as follows:

- **Spatial aspect:** The geographical orientation towards the sea (coastal location) which historically fostered development and wealth generation, albeit with higher risks than inland areas.
- **Demographic aspect:** Population patterns in maritime regions (e.g. dense coastal settlements, migration flows, tourism to coasts).
- **Economic aspect:** The creation of livelihoods and industries based on the sea (the proportion of a population employed in the maritime economy).
- **Social aspect:** Socialization practices, community norms, and patterns of social control that develop in relation to the sea (for example, how growing up in a seafaring family shapes one's worldview, or how port towns develop unique social norms).
- **Cultural aspect:** Human cultural products and creativity inspired by the sea, and the self-definition of humans in relation to the ocean (such as maritime art, folklore, rituals, seafaring heritage).
- **Cultural relevance aspect:** The spread of maritime culture into the broader society – what today might be found in youth maritime education, ocean literacy or the infusion of maritime themes into popular culture and education.
- **Psychosocial aspect:** The formation and development of certain psychosocial traits or communities (the fragment in the source suggests this involves the development of a "maritime ethos" or collective identity among people deeply connected to the sea).

Janiszewski's multi-aspect maritimization shows his commitment to a **holistic, systemic view**: the sea's influence is not just economic or occupational, but also spatial, social, and cultural. He argued that as human civilization progresses (i.e. through urbanization, industrialization, post-industrial and reflexive modernization), there is a correlated *increase* in the role of seas and oceans in economic, technological, cultural, and political life[36]. Thus, maritimization is portrayed as one of the great "universal processes" of civilization, akin to industrialization – a process whereby humanity increasingly engages with, and is shaped by, the maritime realm[37]. He wrote that the historical development of humanity could be seen as correlating with *"the growth of the share of seas and oceans in economic, technological, cultural and political life"*, and he named this ongoing increase the *"process of maritimization"*[38].

Importantly, Janiszewski viewed **proximity to the sea as an independent variable** – a causal factor that can explain certain social differences[39]. In classical scientific reasoning terms, maritimization followed an explanatory model of independent and dependent variables: the *independent variable* of the marine environment (being near or involved with the sea) helps explain variations in the *dependent variables* of social life (like community structure or cultural traits)[39]. For example, he detailed how the sea as a natural-geographical environment exerts: (a) **physical influences** (climate, sea conditions affecting human physiology and health), (b) **psychological influences** (sensory and cognitive effects, e.g. the psychological awe or fear of the sea shaping beliefs and customs), (c) **economic-material influences** (availability of marine resources and hazards dictating forms of human activity), and (d) **population and settlement influences** (patterns of coastal settlement, migration, and urban development)[40][41]. Even international relations can be shaped by the sea (oceans as natural borders forcing cooperation or

conflict)[42]. Janiszewski emphasized that the sea, as a relatively constant and powerful biophysical entity, *"indeed exerts a specific causal influence on societies"*[43]. In this framework, the **agency of the Sea** is recognized – albeit as an involuntary force of nature influencing humans. (He noted that the sea *"regulates climate, provides food and oxygen, and supports biodiversity, creating opportunities and threats"* for societies[44].) This near-deterministic perspective was somewhat novel: whereas mainstream sociology often downplays geographic determinism, Janiszewski placed the environment front and center in sociological explanation.

Alongside maritimization, Janiszewski made significant contributions in delineating the *subject matter and subfields* of maritime sociology. In a 1978 article and later summary (with Adam Sosnowski in 1984), he argued that *"the subject of maritime sociology is precisely maritime social reality"*, comprising the totality of social phenomena linked to the sea[2]. He listed the major problem areas this includes: *"people of the sea"* (*ludzie morza*, meaning seafarers and others whose livelihoods depend directly on the sea), *seafaring communities* (coastal or island communities with maritime cultures), the distinctive nature of life and work at sea, the distinct character of port environments, the social problems of employing seafarers, industrial relations in maritime sectors, the organization of maritime transport (shipping) and ports, and the activities of seafarers' and dockworkers' unions[45]. In short, any social issue that *originates from or significantly interacts with the maritime context* falls under maritime sociology. Janiszewski then grouped this broad array into four **divisions** of maritime sociology assemblage[46]:

1. **Sociology of maritime people** – focusing on seafarers and maritime occupational groups as social collectivities (their demographics, professional culture, family life, etc.). This corresponds to studying the *"people of the sea"* as a distinct social category[47].
2. **Sociology of maritime institutions and organizations** – examining institutions that operate *on the sea, thanks to the sea, or for the sake of the sea*[48][49]. This ranges from shipping companies and port authorities to maritime education, navies, fisheries management bodies, and so forth. It connects with institutional sociology by treating these organizations as units of analysis shaped by the maritime context.
3. **Sociology of maritime territorial communities** – studying communities defined by geographic relation to the sea (port cities, coastal towns, fishing villages – what he sometimes calls *ecological* communities in the maritime sense)[46]. These are populations for whom locality and the sea's proximity form a key part of social identity and structure.
4. **Sociology of maritime social processes** – focusing on broader social processes that are *"determined by the maritime substrate"*[50]. This could include processes like maritimization itself, migration to/from coastal areas, development of maritime education, changes in social stratification due to a growing or declining maritime industry, etc.

By defining these divisions, Janiszewski explicitly cast maritime sociology as a **middle-range theoretical enterprise**. He saw each subfield producing its own mid-range theories explaining phenomena in that domain, rather than one grand theory of everything. In fact, Janiszewski and Sosnowski wrote that the body of knowledge gained from these specific theories *"does not accumulate into some super-general theory, but merely supplements existing knowledge with ever new middle-range theories"*[51]. They characterized maritime sociology itself as a *theoria średniego zasięgu* (theory of middle range) – akin to Robert Merton's concept that sociological

understanding often progresses through partial, context-specific theories rather than all-encompassing laws[11]. This stance acknowledged the limits of generalization: insights about seafarer family dynamics or port-city relationships might not directly yield universal sociological principles, but they enrich our understanding of those particular contexts and can inform broader theory by analogy.

Finally, Janiszewski's contributions must be seen in the context of Polish sociology's broader engagement with maritime issues. He was not alone in this endeavor; rather, he synthesized and advanced a line of thought that included Polańska, Matejko, Sztumski, Woźniak, Sosnowski, and others. Under communist Poland (especially after the country's post-WWII expansion of its Baltic coast), maritime industries were vital, and academic centers in **Gdańsk, Szczecin, and Poznań** cultivated marine research[52][53]. Janiszewski's work benefited from this empirical milieu – numerous studies on seamen's work conditions, fishermen's communities, port city development, and seafarer family life were conducted between the 1950s and 1980s[54][55]. Janiszewski helped give these studies a coherent theoretical framing (maritime social reality and maritimization) and vocabulary (distinguishing *ludzie morza*, *społeczności morskie*, etc.). He also situated sociology among a family of *"maritime social sciences"* including maritime history, economics, psychology, ethnography, and anthropology[56], emphasizing an interdisciplinary outlook. This theoretical canon, largely published in Polish (e.g. in the *Annuals of Marine Sociology* / *Roczniki Socjologii Morskiej*), might have been overlooked internationally, but it laid an essential foundation. In summary, Janiszewski's contributions provided maritime sociology with: a clear *ontological focus* (the distinct maritime social world), a *processual theory* (maritimization) linking environmental and social change, a *taxonomy of research domains*, and an explicit *mid-range theoretical orientation*.

## Comparative Analysis: Ontologies, Methodologies, and Research Objects

Having outlined Poole's and Janiszewski's frameworks, we now compare their approaches along key dimensions: their ontological assumptions about maritime society, their methodological orientations, and the specific research objects or focal topics they emphasize. Despite a common subject matter, the two scholars' perspectives differ in notable ways – reflecting, in part, their intellectual contexts (Anglo-Western vs. Polish sociological traditions) and personal theoretical priorities. Yet there are also areas of convergence, where both recognized similar phenomena or concepts (such as the importance of seafaring communities or the relevance of institutional structures).

**Ontological Perspectives:** Perhaps the starkest contrast lies in how each conceived the **nature of maritime social reality**. Janiszewski adopted what we might call a *realist and particularist ontology*. He posited that the maritime social world has unique characteristics that set it apart from "landed" society[2]. The ocean environment is not just a backdrop but an active presence – a semi-deterministic force that shapes human communities in its orbit. In his maritimization framework, the sea is effectively an independent variable influencing social outcomes[39][40]. This perspective carries a mild geographic determinism: for example, simply living by the sea or engaging in seafaring labor will *inevitably* produce certain social patterns (like seasonal migration cycles, or tight familial structures to cope with a parent's long absence, etc.). Janiszewski thus treated "maritime social reality" as something objectively distinguishable – a **sui generis** domain for sociology to investigate[2]. His ontology also recognized the **duality** of

human-environment interaction: humans shape the sea's use (through technology, economy, culture) even as the sea shapes human society[34][57]. This dynamic interplay is built into maritimization theory.

Poole's ontology, in contrast, was more *integrationist and constructivist*. He did acknowledge that the maritime context has special features – for instance, the "maritime environment" can be defined socially by how people perceive and exploit it[7]. But Poole did not advocate treating maritime society as fundamentally separate from general society. Instead, he saw it as a **subset or extension of human social life** that could be understood with existing sociological concepts. This is why he stressed integrating maritime studies into core sociology[32]. For Poole, the oceanic context requires attention (e.g. acknowledging that life on a ship or in a remote fishing village has distinctive conditions), but these conditions should be viewed through *universal* sociological lenses like social systems, community, or social action. In other words, his approach treats the *differences* of maritime life as differences in degree or manifestation, not in kind. For example, a ship's crew can be studied as a social system much like any isolated work organization, and concepts of role, status, norm, etc., apply there as they would in a factory or monastery – with appropriate adjustments[18][58]. Poole's frequent references to mainstream theory (Weberian action, functional integration, Tönnies' community, etc.) underscore that he considered maritime sociology an *applied sociology* rather than an entirely separate ontology. Another way to frame this is: Janiszewski gave the **sea itself** a prominent ontological status in his theory (almost elevating the ocean to a social actor or determinant), whereas Poole gave primacy to **social actors and structures**, with the sea as the setting that can be factored into analysis. Contemporary scholars note that recent thought has trended towards Janiszewski's direction by "moving beyond terrestrial frameworks" and seeing the ocean as *"an active space of human–nonhuman interaction,"* not just an economic resource[1][59] – effectively validating Janiszewski's instinct to take the sea seriously in sociological ontology, even if in a more *posthumanist* way than his original formulation. Indeed, Polish authors Kowalewski and Bartłomiejski (2020) have argued the "World Ocean" can be seen as a **super-actant** – an agent in its own right – which is an extension of Janiszewski's vision updated with Actor-Network Theory and new materialist perspectives[60]. Poole might not have gone so far, but his work left conceptual space for recognizing the environment by citing how *adaptation to the wider environment* is a necessary function in any social system (citing Parsons)[21].

**Methodological and Theoretical Orientation:** Methodologically, Poole and Janiszewski both valued empirical research, but the *style* of theory-building they embraced was different. Poole was explicitly concerned with methodology in the sense of scientific rigor: he lamented the lack of *"advanced operational designs"* and hypothesis-testing in maritime sociology and called for more **deductive research designs**[12][32]. This reflects a positivist inclination – the idea that maritime sociology should progress by formulating general propositions and then using data (surveys, comparative studies, etc.) to confirm or refine them. For example, Poole pointed out that while early studies identified many factors affecting seafarers' career decisions (the push–pull factors), these often took the form of *"check-lists"* rather than integrated theory[61]. He implied that future research should build on these findings by constructing models (perhaps using exchange theory or labor market theory) and then testing them quantitatively[31]. Similarly, on questions like whether the ship is a total institution or whether seafaring is an occupational subculture, Poole would encourage systematic comparison with land-based analogues and the use of established social theories (e.g. Goffman's criteria for total institutions)

to guide the analysis. In short, Poole's approach is **analytical and hypothesis-driven**, aiming to tighten the link between maritime case studies and general theory through methodology.

Janiszewski's approach, by contrast, can be characterized as **synthesis and conceptual elaboration** at a middle range theory's meso level. He was less concerned with hypothesis testing and more with comprehensive conceptual modeling of the maritime sphere. His work involved assembling a wide range of observations (from demographics to culture) into an overarching explanatory schema (maritimization/ marinization) and into a structured catalog of topics (the subfields). This method is more inductive and systematizing: Janiszewski drew from historical, geographical, and sociological knowledge to propose a broad theory that could *organize* empirical findings. His emphasis on *explanatory variables* suggests a quasi-scientific approach, but in practice he did not conduct statistical tests of maritimization – instead he illustrated it with examples and logical reasoning. The designation of maritime sociology as a "theory of middle range" also signals a certain modesty of scope: Janiszewski did not seek to derive universal laws, but to contextualize and explain specific maritime phenomena in their own terms[51]. Methodologically, this aligns with a **contextual, descriptive-analytical tradition** common in Polish sociology of that era, which often produced rich case studies and typologies (for instance, detailed studies of sailors' family life or port city transformations were common[62][63]) and then generalized within a bounded scope. Polish maritime sociologists indeed did considerable empirical work – e.g. surveys of seafarers' families on how they coped with long absences[64][62], or studies asking *"to what extent can the ship be considered a total institution?"*[63] – but these were usually framed as exploring a facet of the distinct maritime world, rather than as tests of general hypotheses. Thus, Janiszewski's methodological contribution was to encourage **comprehensive description guided by a unifying concept (maritimization)**, whereas Poole's was to encourage **theory-driven inquiry bridging the maritime–terrestrial gap**. Both approaches are valuable: Janiszewski's ensures we fully appreciate what is unique about maritime social contexts, and Poole's ensures we connect those insights back to broader sociological knowledge.

**Research Objects and Foci:** In terms of substantive focus, there is considerable overlap in what Poole and Janiszewski considered important to study, yet some differences in emphasis emerge. **Seafaring people** (*ludzie morza*) are at the heart of both frameworks. Janiszewski explicitly foregrounded this, defining maritime sociology largely as the study of people who live and work at sea (and their onshore counterparts)[47][65]. Poole likewise started from the ship's crew and related workers as the obvious unit of analysis[14]. Both recognized that these occupations (sailors, fishermen, officers, etc.) have distinctive social characteristics worthy of study: for instance, strong occupational subcultures, unique hazards and lifestyle (isolation, danger, mobility), and sometimes marginal status in society.

Both also extend analysis to **families and communities** connected to maritime workers. Janiszewski's domain of "maritime territorial communities" covers port towns, fishing villages, and coastal cities influenced by maritime industries[46]. Poole, for his part, explicitly mentioned the need to include *"shore-based personnel"* such as seafarers' families, acknowledging that the lives of sailors and their families are intertwined and that communities on land (like home port towns) are part of the maritime social ecosystem[66]. Indeed, one area of research in maritime sociology has been the *family as a unit* coping with the seafaring cycle of absence and presence[64][67], and both frameworks legitimize that area: Janiszewski by the broad sweep of

maritimization affecting even those on land, Poole by explicitly citing families and community relations as within scope[68].

When it comes to **institutions and organizations**, Janiszewski dedicated an entire subfield to maritime institutions, meaning not just formal organizations like shipping companies or navies, but also social institutions (norms, roles, possibly legal frameworks) particular to maritime life[46]. Poole did not list "institutions" as a separate category, but his discussion is suffused with institutional considerations: he talks about **companies, governments, and unions** affecting maritime social dynamics[33][69], about **technology and policy changes** reshaping work at sea[33], and about **organizational structures on ships**[18]. In essence, Poole treated institutions as an integral part of every theme (you can't talk about structure or conflict at sea without considering the shipping industry or maritime laws), whereas Janiszewski carved them out for focused inquiry. A subtle difference is that Janiszewski's perspective might encourage analyzing *specifically maritime forms* of institutions – e.g. how a port authority differs from a typical municipal government, or how a seafarers' union has unique challenges – whereas Poole's integrationist view might more readily compare these with analogous land institutions (e.g. seeing a port authority as a case of a bureaucratic organization, comparable to an airport authority).

Another research object is the **maritime** environment *itself (the ocean, the ship, the port as physical space). Janiszewski gave the environment a starring role via maritimization, essentially making the sea an object of sociological inquiry (how it impacts society)[40][41]. Poole, while acknowledging environment under the rubric of "adaptation" and technology, was more focused on social* forces than natural ones. This leads to a difference in topics like environmental issues: Janiszewski's framework easily extends to studying things like how coastal communities respond to ecological changes or how maritime culture incorporates respect/fear of the sea (indeed he included "protection of the marine environment" and "maritime education" as topics in Polish discourse[70]). Poole's 1981 agenda did not explicitly highlight environmental conservation or similar issues; it was more geared to sociological problems internal to maritime industries and communities (though today, a Poolean approach could be applied to, say, climate change impacts on fishermen by integrating environmental sociology theories).

Finally, consider the theme of **social change and modernization**. Both recognized that maritime communities were undergoing change. Janiszewski's concept of maritimization was inherently historical (tracking the rising influence of the sea through time)[36], and within maritime reality, he acknowledged processes like industrialization of shipping, or the decline of traditional fishing, etc., as part of broader societal evolution. Poole devoted a section to "change with special reference to technology"[71] and discussed how new ship technology, shifts in labor markets, and exogenous economic trends force changes in maritime life[72][73]. Both would agree that globalization and technological advancement were (even in the 1980s) altering the face of maritime work – for example, containerization reducing the number of dockworkers needed, or automation changing shipboard roles. They might frame it differently: Janiszewski might call it a new phase of maritimization (with possibly a *directed* element if driven by policy), whereas Poole would analyze it as stimuli for social change requiring adaptation, possibly leading to conflict or shifts from Gemeinschaft to Gesellschaft in seafaring communities[27][74].

**Illustrative Example – The Ship as Total Institution:** A useful lens to compare their approaches is the question: *Is a ship a total institution?* This classic sociological concept (from

Erving Goffman) describes places of residence and work where a large number of individuals are cut off from the wider society for a significant time and lead an enclosed, formally administered life (e.g. prisons, military barracks, monasteries). Early maritime studies often queried whether life aboard ships (especially naval vessels or long voyages) met these criteria. **Polish researchers in the 1970s-80s did study this**, asking *"how much the sea vessel could be considered as an example of a total institution"* and examining shipboard social organization and hierarchy in comparison to land organizations[63]. Janiszewski's framework would accommodate this question as part of understanding the *organizational context* of maritime life (indeed the *ship as platform of interactions* and its social structure was identified as a fundamental research area by later Polish scholars building on his work[63][75]). Poole, on the other hand, explicitly mentioned *"total institution"* as one of the familiar sociological terms used in maritime studies, but he observed it had been applied inductively and needed firmer theoretical grounding[9]. Poole would likely approach the question by carefully defining what makes a total institution and then seeing if ship conditions satisfy those (deductively testing Goffman's framework in the maritime case). Janiszewski might be more inclined to say: whether or not it fits Goffman perfectly, a ship clearly has an unusual social organization worth studying on its own terms (which Polish scholars did, comparing it to other organizations and noting both similarities and differences)[75]. In essence, Poole seeks to *fit maritime phenomena into existing theory*, whereas Janiszewski seeks to *develop theory out of maritime phenomena* (even if at a middle range). Both approaches are complementary – one guards against insular theorizing by linking to general sociology, the other guards against superficial analogies by insisting on the sea's special character.

In summary, **Michael Poole vs. Ludwik Janiszewski** can be seen as embodying two poles on a continuum. **Ontologically**, Poole = maritime society *as a variant* of general social life; Janiszewski = maritime society *as a distinctive reality*. **Methodologically**, Poole = *deductive, theory-testing, integrate with "parent" discipline*; Janiszewski = *inductive synthesis, descriptive depth, standalone theoretical constructs*. **Research foci**, both cover people, communities, and institutions at sea, but Poole emphasizes boundary-defining and mainstream linkages (e.g. where to draw the line on included groups, how to apply general concepts like community, deviance, conflict), while Janiszewski emphasizes exhaustive inclusion of anything maritime (from climate effects to cultural production) within a comprehensive schema. Despite these differences, it's important to recognize they are not opposed so much as addressing different needs of a growing subfield. In fact, taken together, their contributions are quite **complementary**: Janiszewski ensures maritime sociology has its own identity and theoretical richness, and Poole ensures it remains connected to and recognized by broader sociology.

## Legacy and Relevance to Contemporary Marine Social Sciences

Both Michael Poole and Ludwik Janiszewski's theoretical legacies continue to resonate in today's marine social sciences, albeit in evolving forms. As global attention turns toward the oceans – whether in the context of climate change, the "Blue Economy," or sustainable development – the insights from these two scholars remain highly relevant. They laid intellectual groundwork that contemporary researchers are building upon, often in an effort to address modern challenges with a sociological lens. In this concluding section, we discuss how their ideas have influenced subsequent scholarship and why their frameworks are still indispensable for understanding current marine social issues.

**Mid-Range Theories and New Applications:** Janiszewski's insistence on maritime sociology as a set of *mid-range theories*[11][51] has proven pragmatic and fruitful. Rather than searching for a single grand theory, researchers have developed focused theories for specific problems – for example, theories of seafarer **identity and family adaptation**, theories of **maritime safety culture**, or theories of **port city social change**. These align well with Janiszewski's subdivisions (each subfield fostering its own theoretical developments). A case in point is the study of seafarers' families: decades of research (including work by Polish scholars in the 1980s and by international scholars since) have examined how families cope with the long absences of seafarers and the role flexibility required when (usually) the husband/father is away at sea[64][67]. This led to mid-range concepts like the "two-worlds" paradigm (families oscillating between an *absence* phase and a *presence* phase) and identification of support mechanisms needed for these maritime families[76][64]. Such work directly stems from recognizing *"the distinct organization"* of seafaring families[77] – an idea championed by Janiszewski's perspective that maritime social reality has unique facets. Similarly, the notion of **occupational communities** among seafarers and dockworkers, which Poole highlighted via the community/association discussion, has continued to be a valuable framework. It helps explain contemporary issues like why seafarers have a strong transnational brotherhood identity or why dockworker unions remain powerful (hinting at enduring Gemeinschaft elements)[25][26] even in an era of globalized industry.

**Concept of Maritimization and Sustainability:** Janiszewski's concept of *marinizacja (maritimization)*, while formulated decades ago, prefigures many discussions we see today about the growing prominence of the oceans in human affairs. In the early 21st century, policymakers and scientists often speak of the "ocean century" or the need to "re-engage with the ocean" in sustainable ways. The Blue Economy concept – promoting ocean-based economic growth – is essentially about **increasing the role of the oceans in our global economy**, which is maritimization by another name (though driven by a very directed, policy-driven approach)[39][78]. Maritime sociologists today critique the Blue Economy for its techno-economic focus and argue, in line with Janiszewski's thinking, that social and cultural dimensions must be considered to avoid harmful outcomes[79][80]. Indeed, a recent article titled *"The Indispensable Role of Maritime Sociology in Fostering a Just and Sustainable Blue Economy"* explicitly draws on foundational thinkers like Poole and Janiszewski to argue that *"the human-sea relationship transcends purely terrestrial frameworks, with the marine environment itself acting as a significant social influence"*[1]. This statement is a clear echo of Janiszewski's view that the sea is a fundamental factor in social life, now being applied to advocate for a **Blue Economy that accounts for social justice, culture, and community well-being**[81][82]. Poole's legacy is evident here too: his call for integrating maritime issues into general sociological themes means that today's maritime sociologists engage with broader theories of **development, justice, and governance**. For example, they invoke concepts like social equity, power dynamics, and community agency when analyzing Blue Economy initiatives[83][84] – effectively bringing mainstream sociological concerns (inequality, power, etc.) into the marine domain, just as Poole would encourage.

**Maritime Sociology and Sustainability Science:** The mention of "maritime sociology for sustainability science" reflects an emerging interdisciplinary convergence. Sustainability science recognizes that solving environmental problems (like overfishing or coastal climate adaptation) requires understanding human behavior, community structure, and institutional arrangements –

precisely what maritime sociology provides. Janiszewski's work underscored factors like community adaptation to environmental changes (e.g. how a fishing village redefines its relationship to the sea under economic or ecological pressures)[85][86], which is directly relevant to sustainability efforts today. Poole's approach, which includes examining the impacts of technological and policy changes on maritime communities[72][73], also feeds into sustainability science by highlighting the sociological consequences of, say, introducing new fishing regulations or offshore renewable energy projects. Contemporary researchers, building on these insights, have documented how coastal communities reinvent themselves when traditional industries decline – for instance, turning to tourism or heritage showcases as noted in *"Maritime Sociology in the Making"*[87][88]. This kind of work connects directly to sustainable development goals (e.g. sustainable cities and communities, responsible consumption and production in fisheries). It carries forward Janiszewski's notion that *"the way the sea is utilized"* drives social transformations in coastal areas[89][86].

**Institutionalization and Global Reach:** Both Poole and Janiszewski helped legitimize maritime sociology as a field, and their legacy is seen in its *institutionalization*. In Poland, maritime sociology became an accepted subdiscipline by the 1980s, and although interest waned in the 1990s (with the decline of maritime industries during economic transition), the 2000s saw a revival[90]. Polish scholars like R. Bartłomiejski, M. Kowalewski, A. Kołodziej-Durnaś and others have cited Janiszewski as a foundational figure while expanding the field to new issues (e.g. maritime cultural heritage, security, or the notion of the "Ocean as super-actant")[60]. Internationally, what Poole started has grown into a broader marine social science movement. Sessions on maritime sociology began appearing at European sociology conferences in the 2010s[91][92], and networks of researchers across countries now collaborate, indicating the field's global relevance. There is even talk of establishing formal sections or research committees on maritime sociology in sociological associations[91]. The **"Manifesto for the Marine Social Sciences"** published in 2020 (by Bavinck & Verrips) is a rallying call that mirrors many of Poole's and Janiszewski's arguments: it asserts the importance of social science insight in marine affairs and encourages integrating those insights for a sustainable and equitable ocean future[93][94].

**Evolution of Concepts:** Some of the concepts introduced or used by Poole and Janiszewski have evolved with new theoretical trends. For example, Janiszewski treated the sea as an influential backdrop, but as noted, newer theories (posthumanism, actor-network theory) recast the sea as an *actor* or *hyperobject* that interacts with humans on a more equal footing[60]. This doesn't negate Janiszewski's maritimization; rather it enriches it by suggesting the relationship is less one-directional influence and more intertwined agency. Poole's emphasis on testing mainstream concepts in maritime settings has likewise evolved: current researchers often adapt theories of **globalization, transnationalism, or precarity** to maritime labor (e.g. studying how seafarers from developing countries navigate global labor markets, using sociological theories of globalization). This is very much in Poole's spirit of linking the specific (life of a seafarer on a container ship) to the general (global economic structures and cultural flows). Moreover, Poole's highlighting of conflict and deviance in maritime settings[95][96] prefigures today's interest in issues like piracy, drug smuggling, or labor rights abuses at sea – topics that require understanding conflict not only as interpersonal (aboard ship) but structural (inequities in the maritime industry).

In conclusion, Michael Poole and Ludwik Janiszewski provided complementary theoretical foundations for maritime sociology. Poole gave the field academic legitimacy in the West by tying it to core sociological theory and calling for rigorous research designs, ensuring that maritime sociological insights could converse with general sociology. Janiszewski gave the field depth and identity, especially in Eastern Europe, by articulating how and why the maritime context produces a distinct social world worthy of detailed study. Today's marine social scientists, whether they are examining the **"just transition"** for fishing communities, the cultural impacts of offshore wind farms, or the social dimensions of marine conservation, are indebted to these pioneers. Their work reminds us that the ocean is not just a physical space or economic resource, but a **social space** with unique challenges and contributions. In an era when humanity's relationship with the ocean is at a crossroads – facing climate crises, economic opportunities, and calls for blue justice – the mid-range theories of maritime sociology and the integrated approaches advocated by Poole and Janiszewski are more relevant than ever. They help ensure that our pursuit of a "blue" future remains anchored in social understanding, justice, and human well-being, as much as in technology and economics[82][97]. The legacy of these two thinkers, therefore, is a robust framework that continues to guide research and policy towards a more **holistic understanding of the human-ocean nexus**, bridging the insights of the past with the needs of the present and future.

## Conclusion

Maritime sociology's development as an academic field owes a great deal to the foundational contributions of Michael Poole and Ludwik Janiszewski. This comparative analysis has shown that, despite working in different contexts, both scholars tackled similar questions: *What makes maritime social life distinctive? How should we study it? How does it connect to broader social theory?* Poole approached these by weaving maritime topics into the fabric of general sociology – emphasizing theoretical integration, clarity of scope, and methodological rigor. Janiszewski approached them by carving out a dedicated conceptual space for the maritime world – emphasizing the ocean's profound influence on social structures, and systematically categorizing the facets of maritime social reality. Their theoretical frameworks, developed around 1980, addressed key elements like mid-range theory (acknowledging the subdisciplinary nature of maritime sociology), maritimization (the long-term process of society-ocean interaction), the idea of ships and seafaring communities as unique social entities (even, potentially, total institutions), and the inclusion of institutions and culture in analysis.

By comparing their ontologies, we saw that Poole leaned toward a view of continuity between maritime and non-maritime social life, whereas Janiszewski asserted ontological specificity for the maritime realm[2][32]. By examining their methodologies, we noted Poole's call for hypothesis-driven, deductive research[9] versus Janiszewski's inductive, holistic modeling of maritime society[34][46]. And by reviewing their delineation of research objects, we found a shared recognition of key topics – seafarers, port communities, maritime institutions – but with different framing: Poole questioning and extending boundaries[14][15], Janiszewski enumerating and subdividing domains[45][46]. In essence, Poole and Janiszewski can be seen as **"bridge-builder"** and **"map-maker"** respectively: Poole built bridges between maritime case studies and general theory, while Janiszewski mapped the terrain of maritime social reality in detail.

The literature review underscores that their contributions are not merely of historical interest, but living influences in current research. Concepts they developed or employed have been adapted to contemporary issues such as the sustainability of coastal communities, the cultural significance of maritime heritage, and the push for social justice in ocean governance. For instance, the process of maritimization finds new life in discussions of integrating ocean considerations into all aspects of sustainable development, and Poole's advocacy for including social variables in maritime policy analysis is echoed in today's critiques of the Blue Economy's technocratic bias[83][84]. Both scholars' work affirms that purely "terrestrial" social theory is inadequate for marine contexts – we must account for the ocean's peculiar challenges and opportunities, an insight now widely accepted in marine social sciences[1][59].

In conclusion, Michael Poole and Ludwik Janiszewski each provided a theoretical lens through which the maritime world becomes intelligible sociologically: Poole's lens brought the maritime into clearer focus within sociology-at-large, and Janiszewski's lens brought the internal structures of maritime society into sharp relief. Their frameworks, once developed in parallel, now converge in informing a mature maritime sociology that is both outward-looking (engaged with global theory and issues) and inward-looking (attentive to the nuances of maritime life). As we face an era where the fate of human societies and the oceans are increasingly intertwined, the foresight of these two thinkers – in urging us to see the **social** in the **maritime** and the maritime in the social – remains invaluable. The ongoing vitality of maritime sociology in research and its growing importance in policy circles stand as a testament to the solid conceptual edifice built by Poole and Janiszewski, upon which new generations of scholars continue to build[90][91].

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